

**"Not good" implies "bad" but
"not bad" doesn't imply "good"**
New insights into the asymmetry of negation

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The asymmetry of negation, aka negative strengthening



The outcome is not good.

**The outcome
is pretty bad.**



The asymmetry of negation, aka negative strengthening



The outcome is not bad.



Two aims

- ❖ While the asymmetry is usually explained in terms of politeness and face-management, there may be a **deeper asymmetry**, rooted in the **semantics** of evaluative antonyms such as "good" and "bad"
- ❖ I'll point out an analogous asymmetry with scalar implicatures, and discuss some broader implications for our understanding of evaluative language, and of linguistic interpretation more generally

Plan for the talk

- ❖ Some background on negative strengthening
- ❖ A novel **semantic** account of negative strengthening based on multidimensional adjectives (Sassoon 2013, Stojanovic 2016)
- ❖ Valence asymmetries in scalar implicatures
- ❖ Discussion and prospects for future research

Part I

Negative
strengthening:
theoretical and
empirical background

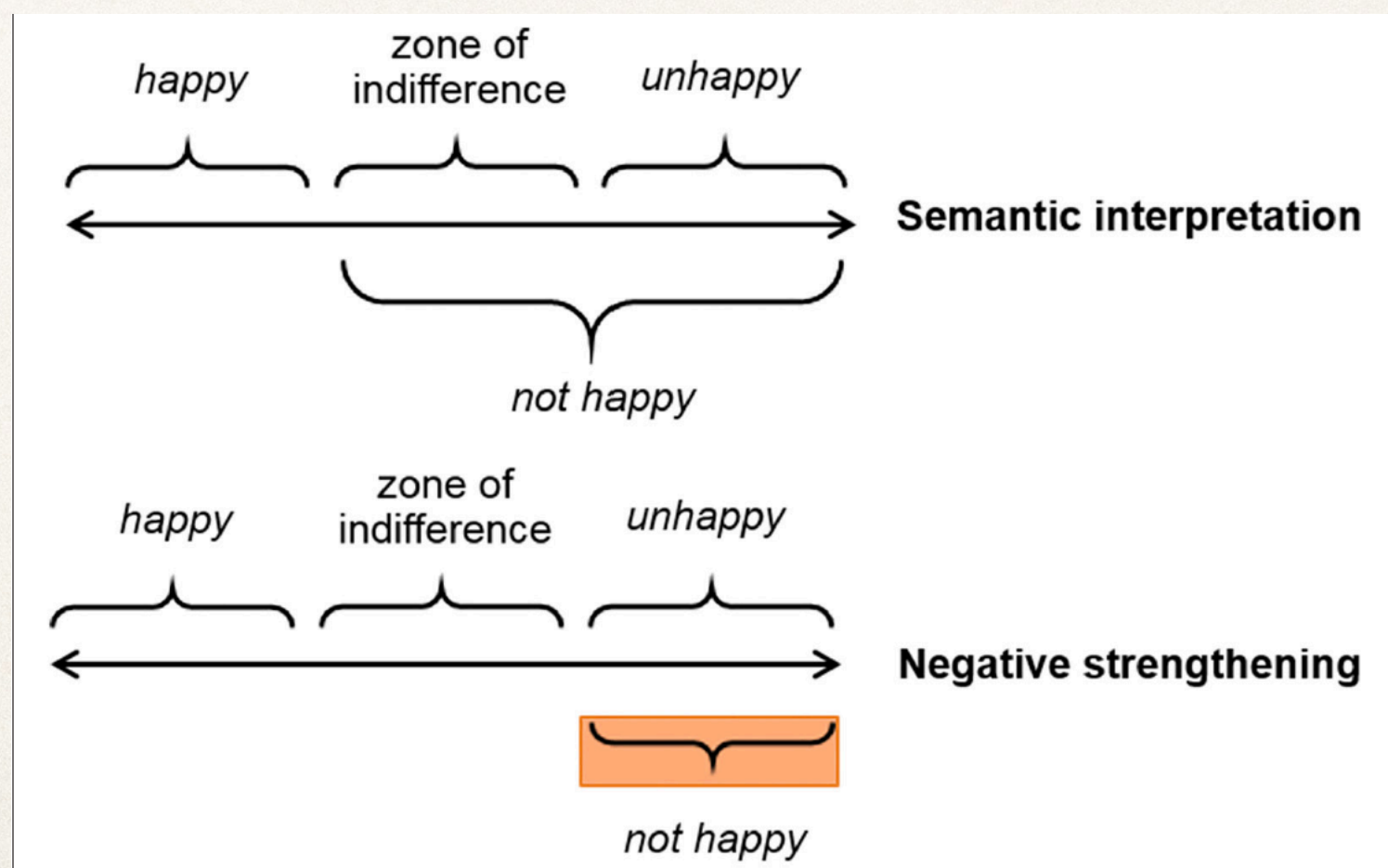


Negative strengthening

- ❖ Negative strengthening was noted in early 1970's (Horn 1972, Ducrot 1973) and discussed at length in Horn 1989
- ❖ Horn 1989 explains it by the principle - “*Say no more than you must*” -: the listener strengthens the negation of an antonym to a more specific, contrary understanding
- ❖ For Horn, then, the phenomenon is crucially driven by a combination of social and pragmatic principles

Contraries vs. contradictories

- ❖ Negative strengthening only occurs for contraries; for contradictories, negating a term logically implies its antonym (eg: open-closed, alive-dead, even-odd...)



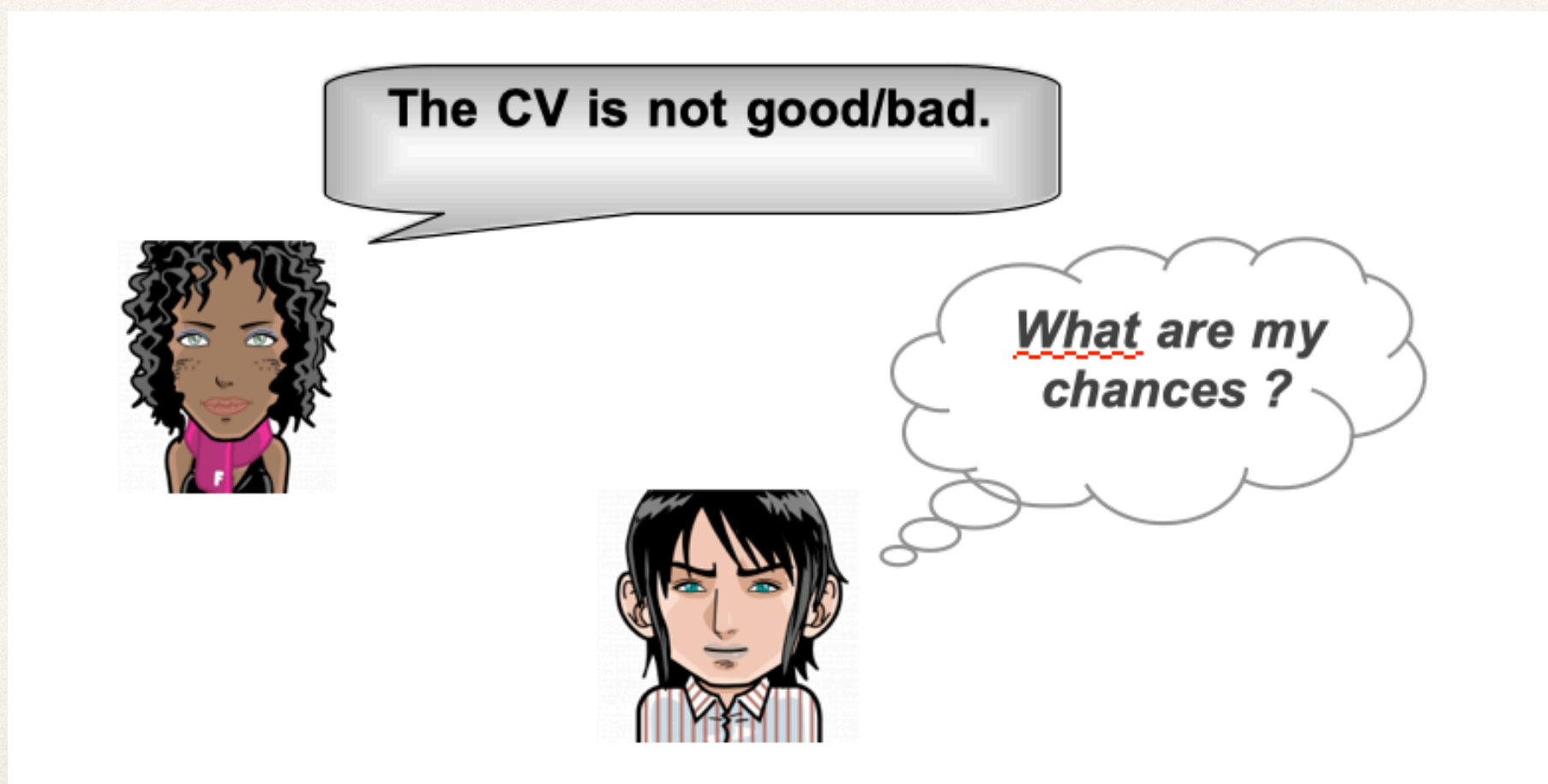
from Mazzarella
& Gotzner 2020

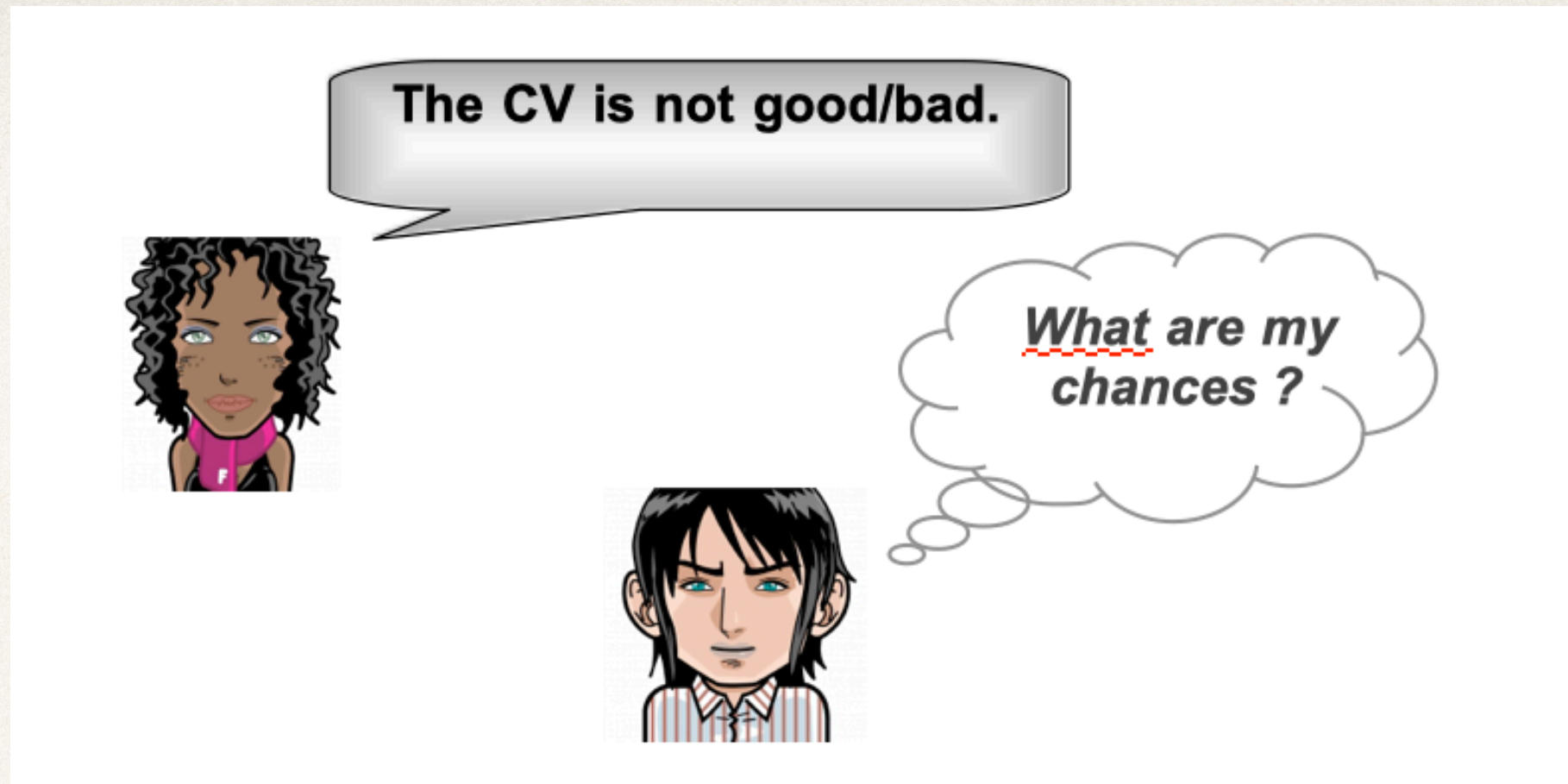
Experimental work

- ❖ Colston's *"Not good" is "bad," but "not bad" is not "good": An analysis of three accounts of negation asymmetry* (1999) reports four studies that show that when events are expected to turn out positively, we get the asymmetry, but not so when events are expected to turn out negatively. He explains it (like Horn) via relevance and politeness
- ❖ Ruytenbeek, Verheyen & Spector (2017) show that "the inference to the antonym" is primarily driven by the lexical valence of the negated term

Experimental work (cont'd)

- ✧ In a series of studies, Mazzarella and Gotzner have been testing the role of lexical valence (polarity) w.r. to other factors; they show that lexical valence takes priority over politeness





Politeness approach

Lexical valence
approach

Listener's CV

asymmetry

asymmetry

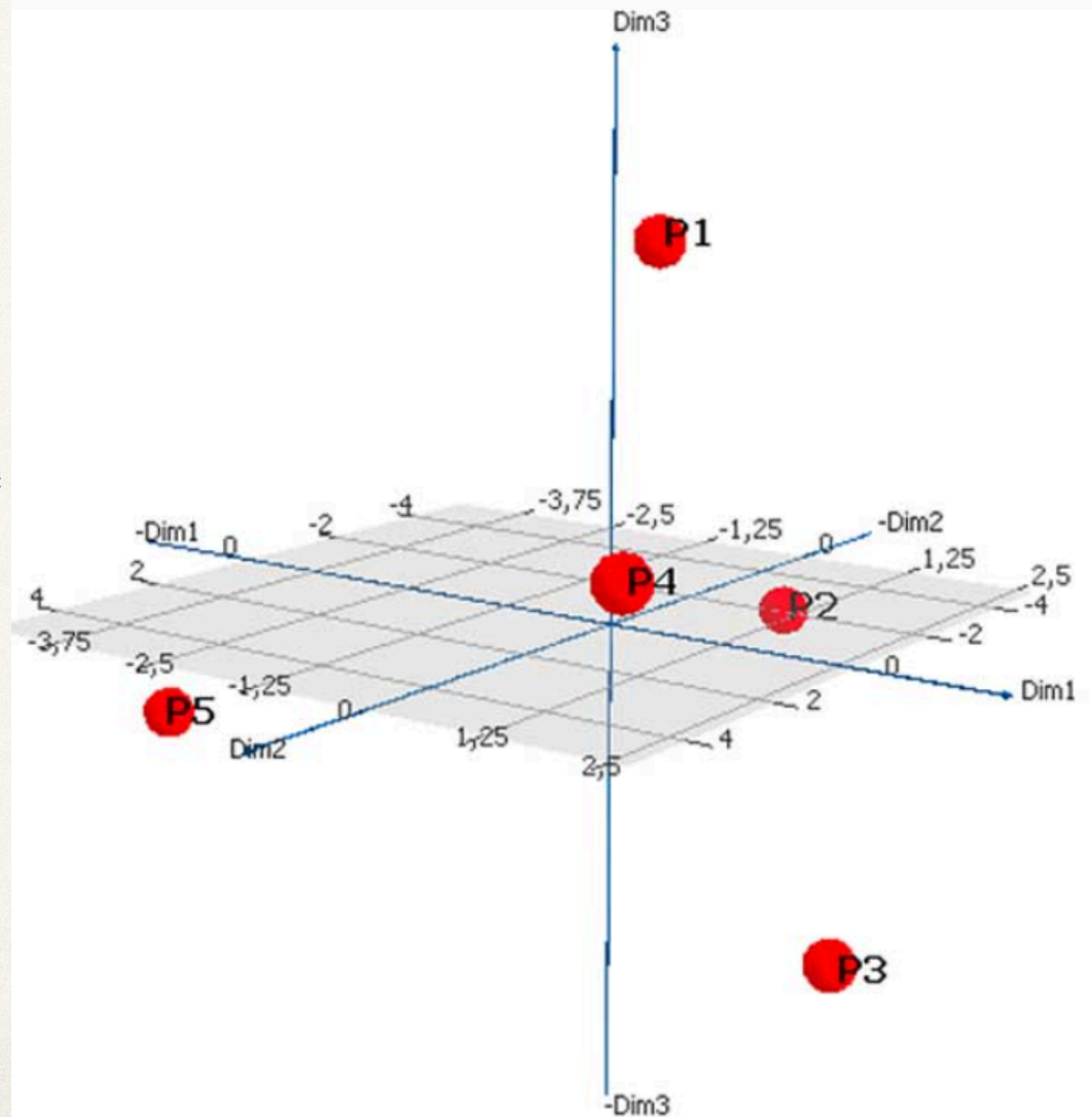
Competitor's CV

no asymmetry

asymmetry

Part II

Multidimensional adjectives



A snapshot at multidimensional adjectives

- ❖ They are gradable adjectives (Klein 1980, Kennedy & McNally 2005) referring to properties that can be held to different degrees
- ❖ They appeal to multiple criteria to decide whether the property holds or not (Bierwisch 1989, Sassoon 2013, McNally & Stojanovic 2017, D'Ambrosio & Hedden 2023)

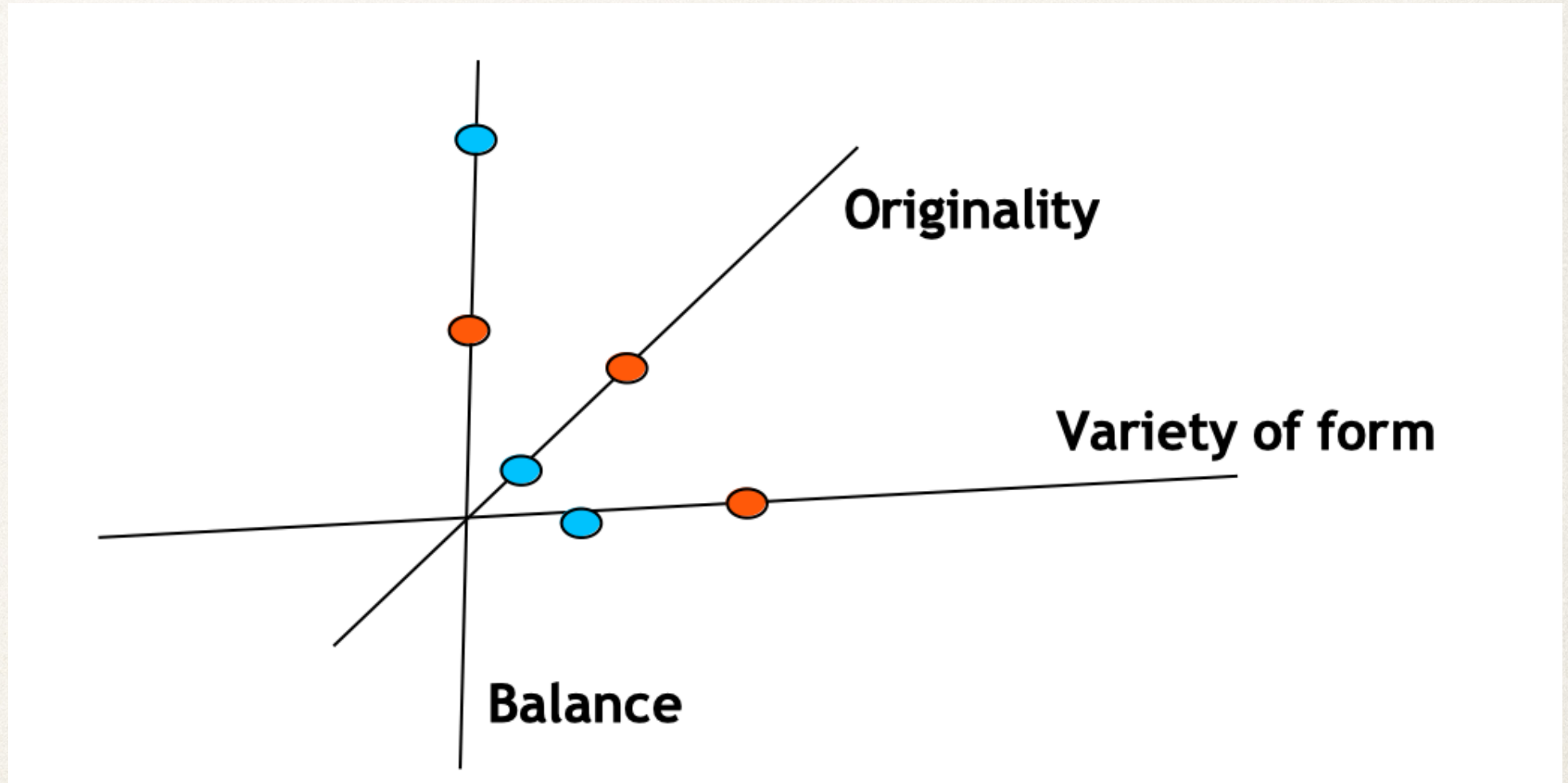
Multidimensionality and subjective disagreements



Cha Jun-hwan



Ilia Malinin



Two takes on 'good'-'bad'

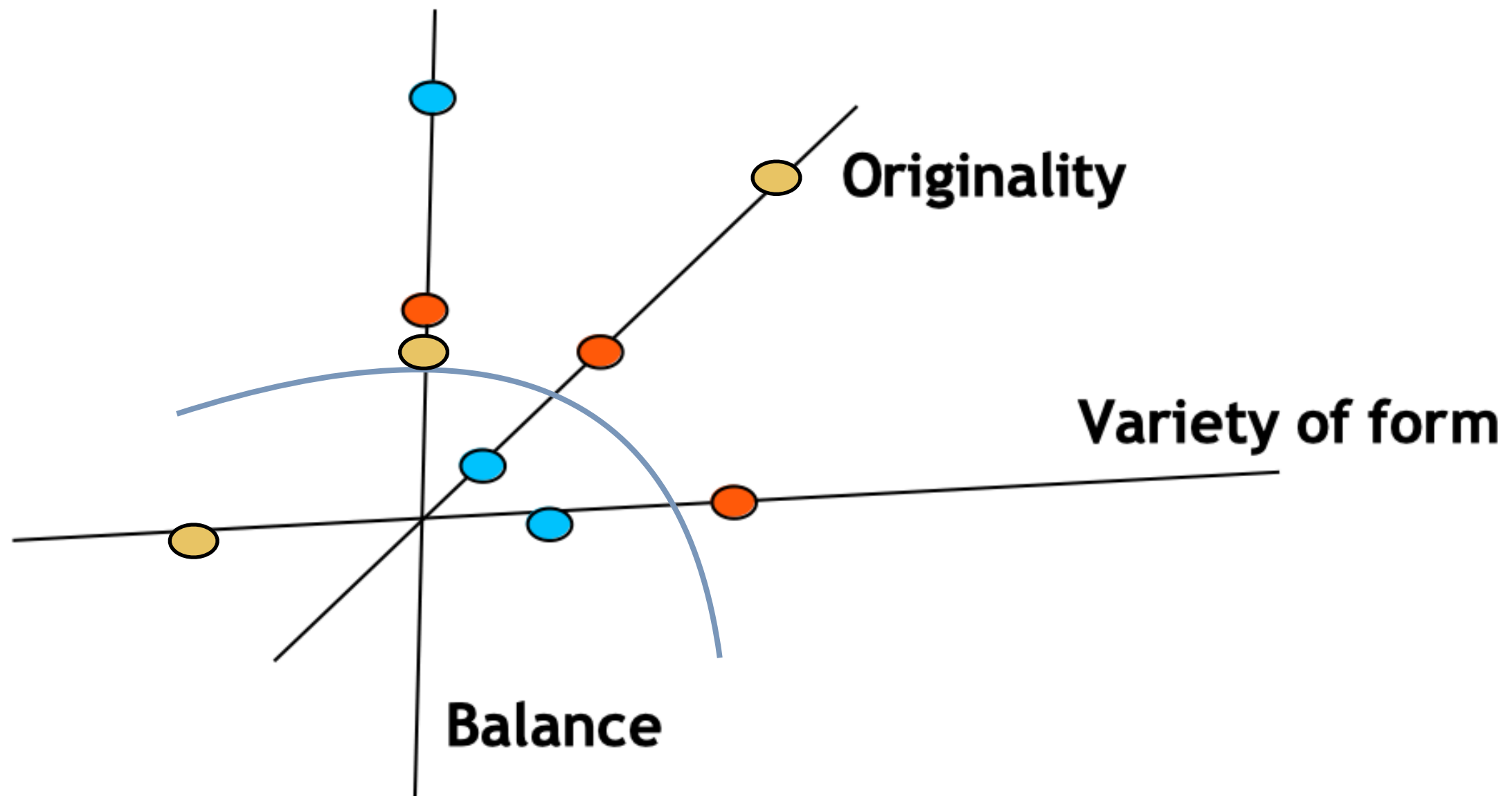
- ❖ In Stojanovic (2016), I proposed a toy semantics for 'intense': a ranking gets computed by factoring in the weight of dimensions (scale) and the score on each scale
- ❖ Applying the idea to 'good'-'bad': first step, you establish a ranking by taking into account the relevant dimensions (and weights); second step, you fix the thresholds



Conjunctive vs. disjunctive adjectives (Sassoon 2013)

- ❖ Sassoon suggests that for many antonym pairs, the positive member is conjunctive: it holds if the object meets some relevant threshold *on every dimension*, while the negative is disjunctive: it holds if the object meets the opposite threshold *on some dimension*
- ❖ "As a default, the dimensions of adjectives such as *healthy* are bound through implicit universal quantification, while those of adjectives such as *sick* are bound through existential quantification. In adjectives like *intelligent* the force of quantification over dimensions is context relative"

'good' and 'bad' as conjunctive and disjunctive

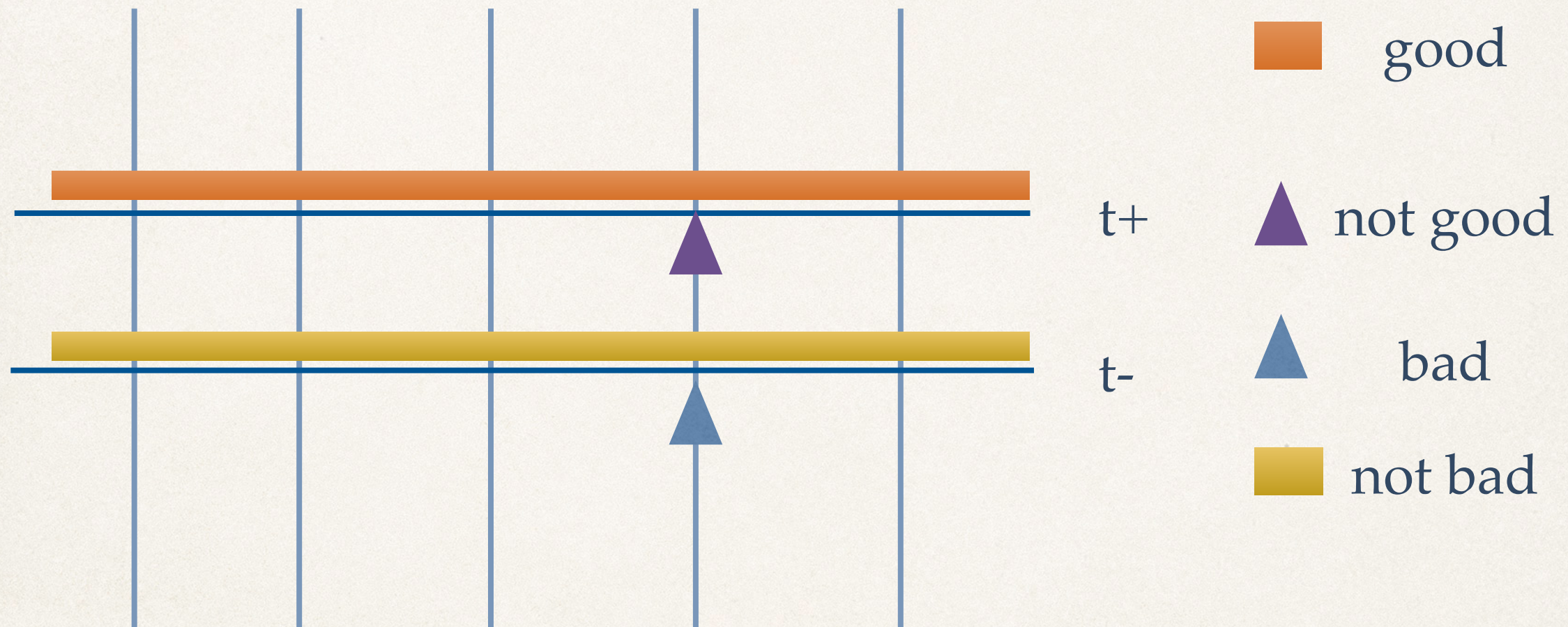


Side note: Diogenes on virtue/vice

- ❖ The conjunctive-disjunctive asymmetry applies to many valenced antonyms:
- ❖ Virtuous:= has all the virtues (to a significant degree)
Vicious:= has at least one vice (lust, corruption, greed, etc.)



Going from 'not good' to 'bad' is easier than from 'not bad' to 'good'



The asymmetry of inferential leaps



The idea, then, is that it is easier to make an inferential leap from 'not good' to 'bad' (you just need to go down on one dimension) than from 'not bad' to 'good' (you need to go up on every dimension)

Part III

Valence asymmetries in scalar inferences



A snapshot at scalar implicatures



The CV is good.



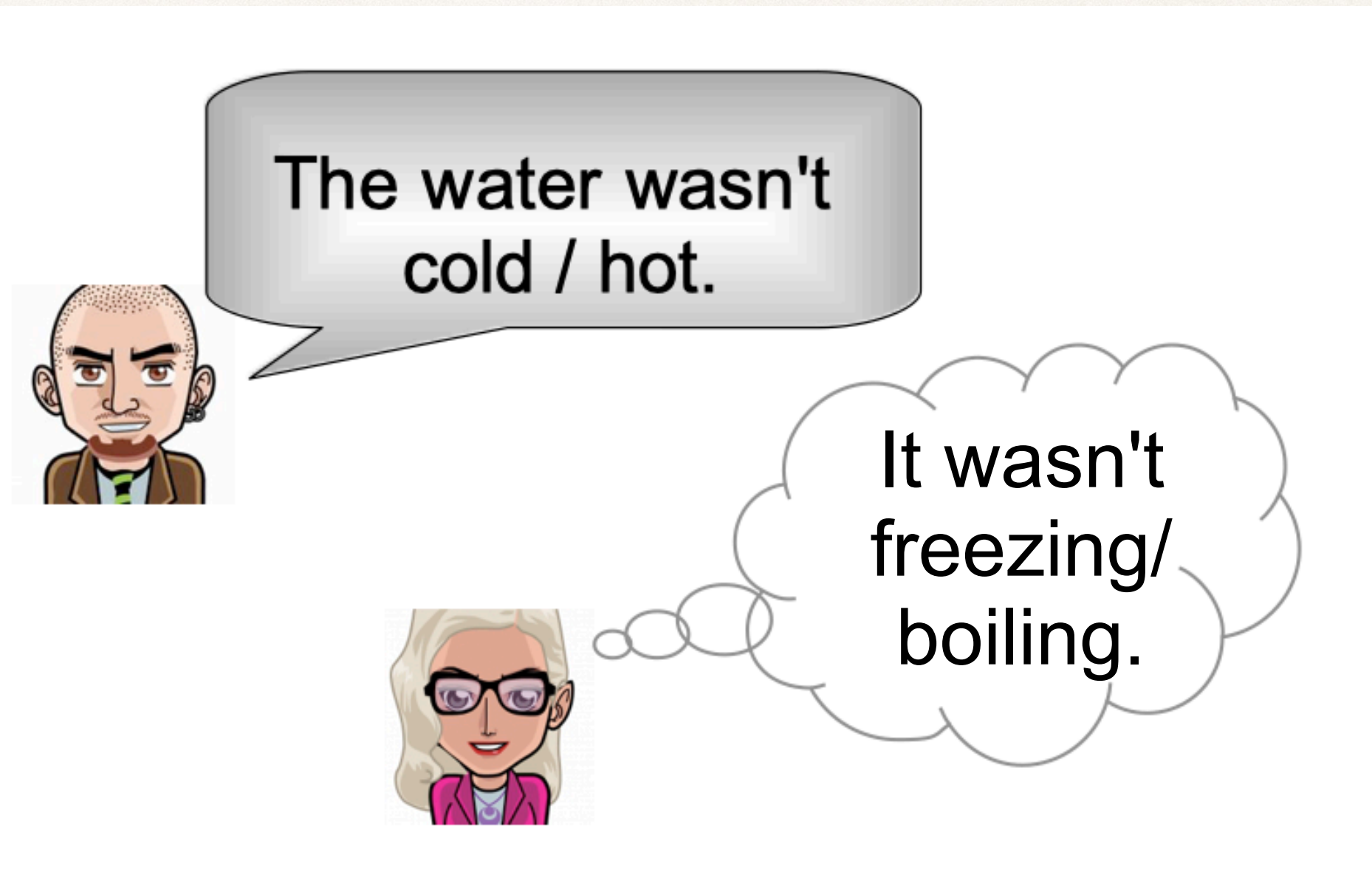
**The CV is not
excellent.**

The standard view of scalar inferences (Horn 1972, 1989, i.a.)

- ❖ If a speaker asserts content c when there exists a stronger alternative content c^* , the hearer (defeasibly) infers that the speaker doesn't believe c^*
- ❖ Examples of Horn scales (Israel 1996, p. 702):

⟨all, most, many, some⟩	⟨none, hardly any, few⟩
⟨necessary, likely, possible⟩	⟨impossible, unlikely, uncertain⟩
⟨boiling, hot, warm⟩	⟨freezing, cold, cool⟩
⟨adore, love, like⟩	⟨loathe, hate, dislike⟩
⟨excellent, good, OK⟩	⟨terrible/awful, bad, mediocre⟩

The standard view doesn't posit any asymmetry



A hitherto unnoticed valence asymmetry in scalar inferences



The CV is bad.

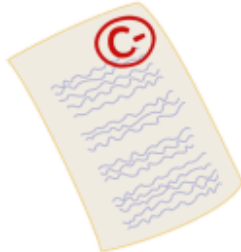
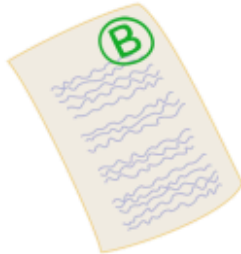
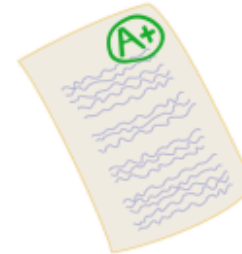


**The CV is
not awful.**

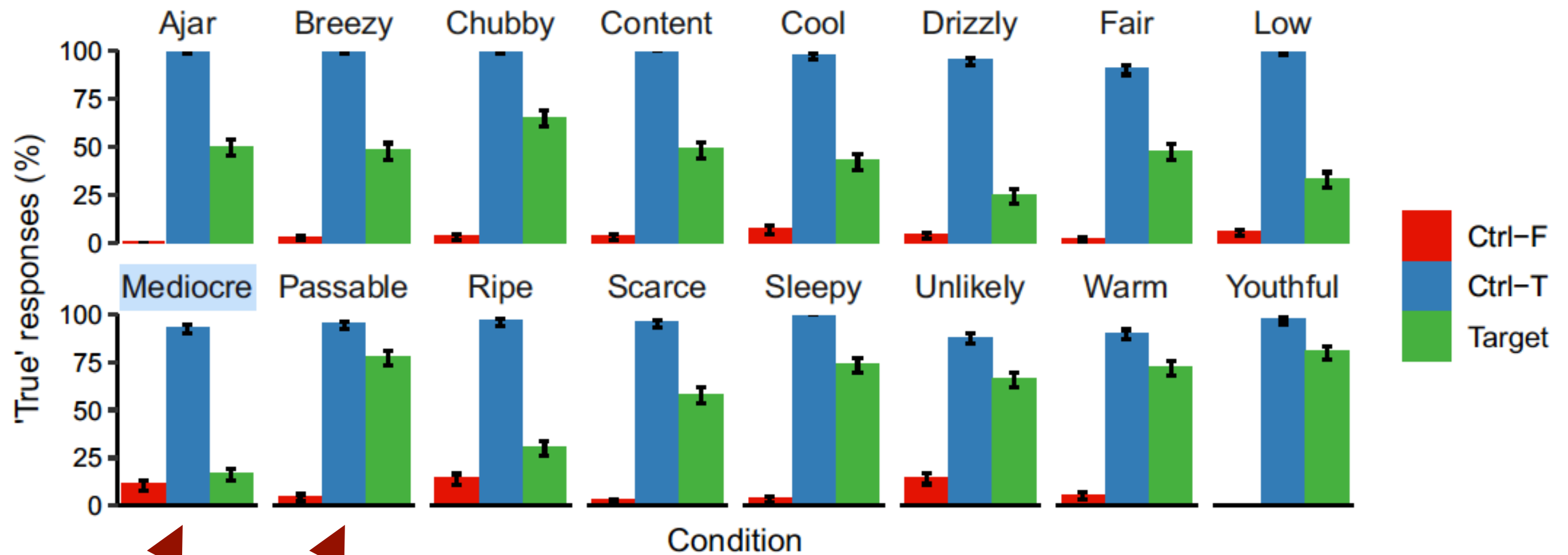
Scalar inferences: empirical data

- ❖ While there is a very large and evergrowing experimental literature on scalar inferences in experimental pragmatics, the main research questions have had to do with processing costs (eg time) but none at valence
- ❖ The next natural step would be to investigate experimentally whether there is a valence asymmetry in scalar implicatures (in English but also other language)

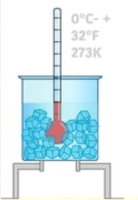
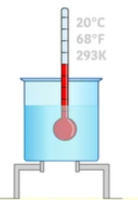
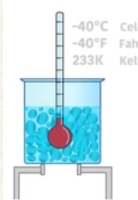
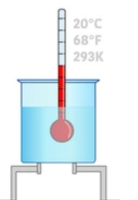
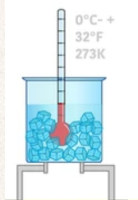
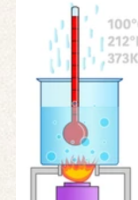
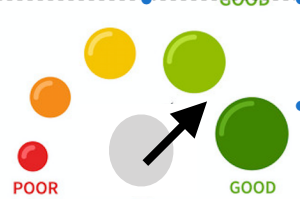
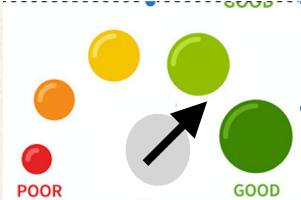
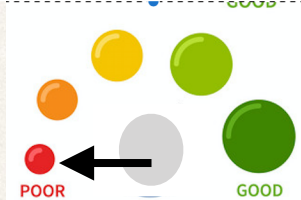
van Tiel & Pankratz (2021)'s study

<i>Sentence</i>	<i>True</i>	<i>False</i>	<i>Target</i>
The door is ajar.			
Her grade is mediocre.			
Her grade is passable.			

the results don't appear to support the asymmetry (but there's a reason)



Improving on the stimuli

	Control-TRUE	Control-FALSE	TARGET
The water was cold.			
The water was warm.			
The score was good.			
The score was bad.			

Part IV

Wrapping up



Valence asymmetries are ubiquitous

- ❖ Psychologists have shown that negative information is recalled more vividly and for longer ("bad is stronger than good", Baumeister et al. 2001), but also, that we use positive language more often than negative (*the Polyanna Hypothesis*, Boucher & Osgood 1969)
- ❖ The Knobe effect (Knobe 2013, a.m.o.) shows that we blame more readily others for the negative side-effects of their actions than praise them for the positive ones

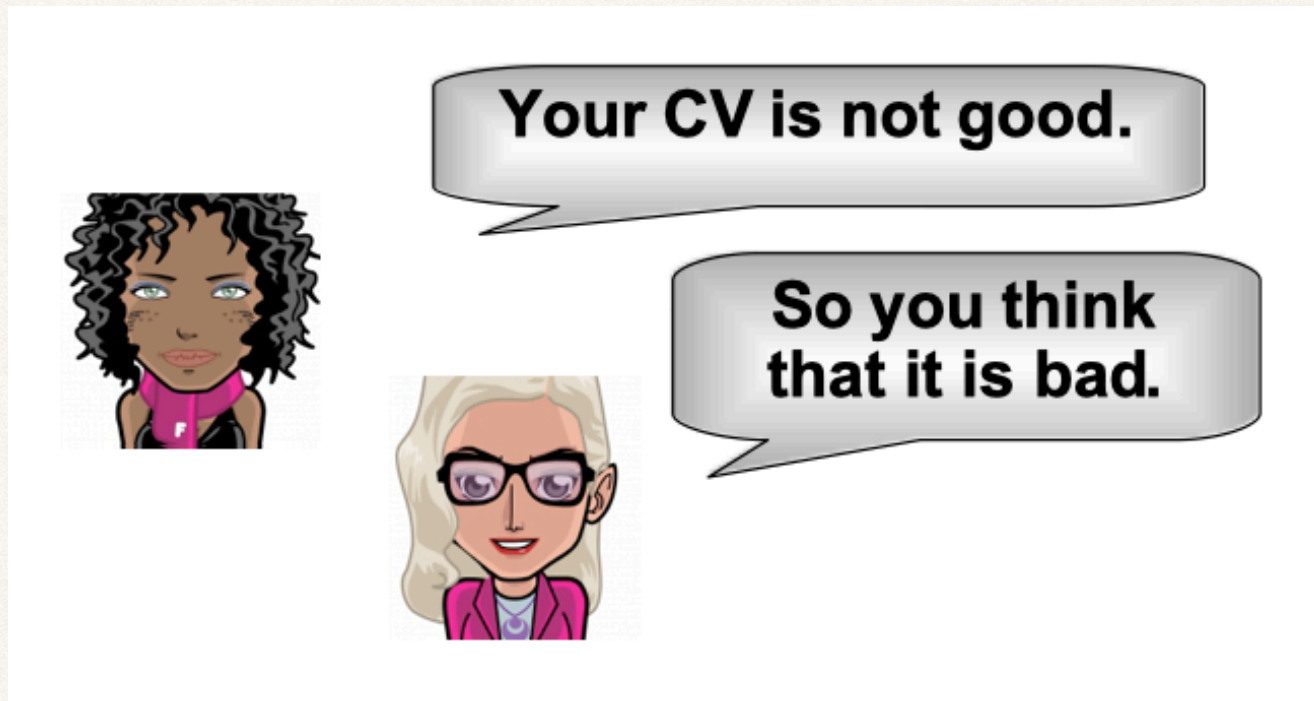
What underlies negative strengthening?

- ❖ Following Horn, negative strengthening is accounted for in terms of (broadly Gricean) pragmatics and politeness
- ❖ Mazzarella & Gotzner (2021)'s study shows that the effect persists even when face management considerations are absent, suggesting that there is a lexical or semantic basis
- ❖ I've offered a novel explanation that relies on a **semantic** asymmetry between positive and negative properties

Limits of the semantic account

- ❖ The semantic asymmetry is independently motivated for antonyms like good / bad, virtuous / vicious, beautiful / ugly
- ❖ It aims to **complement**, rather than **replace**, accounts based on politeness, face-management, and pragmatics
- ❖ Pragmatic competition also accounts for many cases, eg: "Not uninteresting" - / -> "interesting" (cf. 'BE BRIEF')

A broader picture of linguistic interpretation



- ❖ Is the inference really cancellable:
"Oh no, I only said it wasn't (?) good / ✓ good enough"
- ❖ This raises an array of interesting issues on how non logically implied, yet lexically (even semantically) borne inferences enter the process of linguistic interpretation

Thank you
for your
attention!

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